

WE ARE GAMING!

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When one thinks of Virtual Reality or VR, the first application that comes to mind is gaming. VR would be the ultimate next step to having the most immersive gameplay experiences. After all, what's more immersive than actually being in the midst of all the action yourself?

Today, we've got quite a few AAA titles on VR, including the likes of Bethesda's VR versions of Skyrim and Fallout 4, Capcom's Resident Evil 7 and of course, Valve's fantastic Half-Life: Alyx, just to name a few.



Other than the ones mentioned above, there are a ton of light VR titles as well, such as Beat Saber, Boneworks and many more.

TAKING THE FIRST STEP

However, up until Half-Life: Alyx happened, VR offerings were simply an add-on; it was still a concept in the minds of most gamers, and an expensive one at that. Light games like Beat Saber existed just to explore VR, and were never going to be considered full-fledged games. They were more like minigames. With Half-life: Alyx, Valve showed the world that VR is more than a concept, and a full-fledged AAA game for VR is a possibility. They even created their own VR headset, the Valve Index, to show



that they're going all in on VR. As it stands right now, Half-Life: Alyx is the peak of VR gaming, however, it's just the start. As fantastic an experience Half-Life: Alyx is, we're nowhere near the kinds of VR experiences we were first promised when the Oculus Rift first launched after its Kickstarter campaign in 2016. Up until that point we had consumed enough VR related pop culture to have some very lofty expectations of VR. 2018's Ready Player One, and 2012's anime sensation Sword Art Online are the first to come to mind, where the main characters seemingly completely travel from the real world to the game's world. There are also movies like Tron and the Matrix which don't necessarily involve gaming elements, but certainly play their part in creating an image of what Virtual Reality should be or feel like.

In the gaming industry, widespread adoption of VR is still yet to happen. Don't get us wrong, it's certainly more than it was five years ago, but even today most AAA titles don't come with inherent VR support and even when they do have it, it's usually finicky at best. This is why Half-Life: Alyx is so important, it's the first truly AAA title that's made for VR, and when an industry leader like Valve makes such a step, more are sure to follow.

THE NEXT STEP

We've already discussed the various issues with VR adoption, the biggest of which is the cost. At launch, the HTC Vive and Oculus Rift cost over \$500 each, which is a lot of money to spend on hardware that you'll barely use for a few hours to play a small selection of niche games.

Thankfully, VR hardware prices are dropping, and a drop in price not only means more potential gamers, but more VR-focused games in general. VR headsets came with a lot of hardware limitations as well; you don't truly feel immersed with a leash tethered to your head. Now, VR headsets like the Oculus Quest are not only lighter, but also wireless. Furthermore, it's cheaper too! As the tech starts becoming more mainstream,